The Master *Storyteller*

Vidhu Vinod Chopra does not know how to mince words, and that is true of his filmmaking too

By SUHANI SINGH

"I am such an arrogant a**hole," says filmmaker Vidhu Vinod Chopra after an exercise in self-admiration. It's an honest declaration that many in the audience—Naseeruddin Shah, Kamal Haasan, Shabana Azmi among them—would agree with. They have all gathered at a PVR multiplex in Mumbai to celebrate 45 years of Chopra's films. It has been a week-long run of films he has produced over the course of his fascinating career. They are seminal films of Hindi cinema—*Parinda* (1989), *1942 A Love Story* (1994), *Munna Bhai MBBS* (2003), *Lage Raho Munna Bhai* (2006), *3 Idiots* (2009) and *PK* (2014). But Chopra isn't content walking down memory lane. At 71, he is still doing what he knows best—telling stories, his way.

The latest one is *12th Fail*, a true story about IPS officer Manoj Kumar Sharma, who battled innumerable odds in his quest to crack the UPSC examinations, including faring poorly in his school-leaving exam because he chose not to cheat. Adapted from Anurag Pathak's book of the same name, it's a drama that hits all the emotional buttons and features a poignant performance by Vikrant Massey. The film also shines a light on India's multi-crore coaching industry, where institutes are known to issue deceptive advertisements and alumni testimonials to lure aspirants. It moved the Union commerce and industry



MAN, DOG & CRAFT Still from Vidhu Vinod Chopra's latest film, *12th Fail*, starring Vikrant Massey as the lead character Manoj; (right) the man himself